



Hampi

A treasure trove of sacred and secular architecture, hailed as the world's largest open-air museum



△ COURTESAN'S STREET

This temple street is the main approach to the exquisite Achyutaraya Temple. Lined with intricately carved pillars, the street was one of the liveliest marketplaces of the Vijayanagar empire.

Hampi in Karnataka, India, rose to prominence as the capital of the Hindu Vijayanagar empire (1336–1646). By the early 15th century, it was one of the largest and most prosperous cities in the world. Spanning several centuries and covering around 16 square miles (41 square km), the World Heritage Site includes some 1,600 ruins, from spectacular temples, palaces, and shrines to roads and irrigation systems. Local granite, burnt bricks, and lime mortar were among the primary building materials.

Architectural riches

Hampi's architectural treasures include the pre-Vijayanagar, 7th-century Virupaksha (Shiva) Temple, the tower of which soars to 160 ft (49 m). The centerpiece of the Vijayanagar period, however, is the 15th-century Vittala Temple complex, with its magnificent sculpture and huge pillars and courtyard. The Vijayanagar architects are renowned not only for intricate carvings and monolithic pillars but also for their massive *gopurams* (gateway towers), which mark the entrances to some of the temples.



△ STONE CARVINGS

Hampi is renowned for the outstanding stone carvings and reliefs that adorn its buildings, often depicting hunting scenes, warriors, and animals.

ROCK CUTTING

Many of Hampi's buildings are made from local granite. To cut slabs of rock for use in buildings, it is believed that a series of holes was made in the surface of a rock. Wooden pegs were then inserted into the holes and saturated with water. The pegs gradually expanded, causing the boulder to crack.

